COMMONS · RESEARCH BRIEF · LAYER C

The bottleneck is not access to AI. It is how AI practice spreads between colleagues.

6 Oct 2026 · Builds on *competitive-landscape.md* (5 Oct) plus new research on diffusion science, why people hide AI use, 15 enterprise rollouts and historical analogs

At most companies, 50–75% of workers now use AI weekly. Value is still concentrated: **practitioners are 3–5.5% of staff** (Section), and **organizational factors explain 67% of AI impact** (Microsoft WTI 2026). At JPMorgan, the split was the same at every scale of rollout: **30% active, 10% super-users, 60% slow**. The open problem is moving that middle 60%. No product today closes the loop for it.

Where the market is, layer by layer

LAYER	WHO SERVES IT TODAY	STATUS
A · Adoption analytics	Native dashboards from OpenAI, Anthropic and Microsoft (free); Larridin ($17M a16z), Worklytics; DX, Jellyfish, Faros for engineering	CROWDED Commoditizing every month. Not a business on its own.
B · Internal skill/agent store	Claude org skills, ChatGPT Skills, Copilot Agent Store and Prompt Gallery, Gemini Agent Gallery, Glean library. All free and bundled	WALLED Each covers only its own vendor. None ranks by outcomes.
C · Peer diffusion	Champion playbooks (services), Viva Engage communities, Section's use-case coach ($40M), cohort L&D (Uplimit, Electives)	OPEN Nobody runs *detect → package → target → measure uplift* across vendors.

Eight insights from the new research

1. **Diffusion depends on clusters reaching a threshold, not on a champion ratio.** In a Microsoft RCT across 66 firms (7,137 workers), coworkers holding Copilot licenses had almost no effect on a worker's use. In Microsoft's own 2026 coding-agent rollout, people were **3.2× more likely to try** once 25%+ of their skip-level group used it. "One champion per 20" is sparse seeding, and sparse seeding doesn't spread.
2. **Peers get people to try; fit to their own work keeps them.** Peer exposure raised the odds of trying by +216% but of retention by only +66%. A manager using the tool raised trial by +82% and retention by +22%. Recruiting and retaining are two different products.
3. **Peers need to see the work, but being watched by an evaluator suppresses it.** 57% of employees hide their AI use. Being visible to an evaluator cut AI use by 14% and lowered accuracy. Saying "I used AI" lowers trust. Share sideways to peers, never up to managers. Share the method, not the admission.
4. **The people with the best workflows have the strongest reasons to hoard them.** Frequent AI users are 2× as likely to fear losing their jobs. 36% of people who hide AI use do it to keep a "secret advantage". Sharing has to raise the author's standing.
5. **Libraries don't spread practice. Only about 20% of shared assets get reused.** At BBVA, 20,000+ GPTs were built and about 4,000 are used often. On skills.sh, the top 1.2% of skills get 94% of installs. Meanwhile OpenAI is retiring custom GPTs. The assets that do get reused attach to moments every employee goes through, such as a self-review or benefits enrollment.
6. **A workflow people can run beats one they are taught.** In a call center, a tool built from top agents' chats made novices with 2 months' experience as good as agents with 6+ months. The skill stuck when the tool went offline. Simply informing workers about AI changed nothing. Rewriting users' prompts for them made results 58% worse, so people have to adapt workflows themselves.
7. **Usage metrics get gamed. Count how many colleagues adopt a workflow.** Meta's "Claudeonomics" leaderboard, Amazon's "Kirorank", Shopify's token leaderboard and Duolingo's AI review metric were all scrapped after people gamed them. A metric to use instead: *colleagues still using your workflow 30 days later*.
8. **Collecting from the top 10% only can dry up their contributions.** Top call-center agents increasingly copied the AI's suggestions, which left "fewer original contributions" for the next model to learn from. The system must reward new workflows, not only copies.

> **What this means for Commons.** Layer C should be a **targeting and retention engine**, not a feed or a library:
>
> - Find the org units where 10–25% of people already use a workflow.
> - Show each person the same workflow from three different parts of their network.
> - Attach it to a task they repeat, so the first use comes from their own work.
> - Credit the author with "colleagues who kept using it" and put the proof into the seat-renewal case.
>
> The buyer is the Head of AI or CIO, who faces seat renewals and needs proof the seats are used. L&D budgets are only about $468 per learner at large companies.

THE EVIDENCE BEHIND EACH INSIGHT

1 · Diffusion depends on clusters reaching a threshold, not on a champion ratio

Lab evidence. In Centola's experiments (*Science*, 2010), a behavior reached 54% of people in clustered networks vs 38% in random ones, and spread more than 4× faster. A second reinforcing signal significantly raised adoption, and a third raised it a little more. People who got 2–3 signals were 2–3× more likely to keep engaging. A 2018 follow-up found a committed minority of 25% flipped a group norm, while 21% failed.

A natural experiment in a large company. Microsoft studied tens of thousands of engineers adopting Claude Code and Copilot CLI (arXiv, Jul 2026). The share of *skip-level peers* (people under the same manager's manager) who already used the tool was the strongest predictor of trying it. Close code-review partners mattered less.

Increase in odds of trying, by share of skip-level peers already using (Microsoft, 2026)



The control that shows the opposite. In a Microsoft RCT of M365 Copilot across 66 firms (7,137 workers), **licenses scattered at random had almost no peer effect**. Raising the share of licensed coworkers to the median changed usage by about 0.15 pp. **Which firm a worker was in explained 18% of variation in usage, and the worker's own past behavior explained 9%.** Usage peaked at 55% and settled near 40%.

So → Rank org units by distance to the threshold and focus power-user effort on units already at 10–25%. Show a laggard the same workflow from about 3 *different* contexts (a teammate, an adjacent team, their manager). Repeated pings from one champion don't count as separate signals. The 25% threshold link between the lab and the field data is our own synthesis; neither study states it.

2 · Peers get people to try; fit to their own work keeps them

In the Microsoft study, trial was social, but retention was "substantially behavioral". It tracked each engineer's own work cadence. Engineers already on IDE Copilot were *more* likely to try the new tool but **12–15% less likely to keep** using it, because a familiar tool was an easy fallback. In the M365 RCT, use fell from 55% to about 40% by months 4–6. Microsoft's own survey says value is felt at about 11 minutes saved per day, after about 11 weeks. †

So → Build two mechanisms. A social layer gets the first run. A retention layer ties the workflow to a *recurring* task (month-end close, weekly report, claim intake) and reinforces it through the first quarter. Expect users with an existing habit to churn, and target them separately.

3 · Peers need to see the work, but being watched by an evaluator suppresses it

Rogers' diffusion theory says *observability* drives adoption, but AI use happens in private 1:1 chats, so colleagues can't see it.

- **People hide it.** 57% of employees hide their AI use and present AI work as their own (KPMG/Melbourne, 48k people). 48% wouldn't tell their manager. Their reasons: it feels like cheating (47%), it looks less competent (46%), it looks lazy (46%) (Slack, 17k).
- **Disclosing makes it worse.** Across 13 experiments, people who disclosed AI use were trusted less than people who stayed silent. Being exposed by someone else was worst of all (Schilke & Reimann, 2025).
- **Visibility to an evaluator suppresses use.** In a field experiment with 450 Upwork workers, it cut reliance on AI from 30.5% to 26.2% and lowered accuracy from 79.1% to 76.4% (Almog, 2025).
- **The penalty falls hardest on women.** At a firm with 28,698 engineers, identical code was rated 9% less competent when the reviewer believed AI was used: 13% for women, 6% for men. Women's adoption was 31%, against 41% overall (HBR, Aug 2025).
- **The penalty disappears in two cases:** when the evaluator uses AI often, or when the task is obviously suited to AI (Duke, PNAS 2025, N=4,439).
- **How peers learn.** 6 of 10 Copilot users learned mainly from peers, and 0 of 10 from formal training (Columbia interviews; small sample). 94% wanted to see a partner's prompts, but *after* the output was accepted, not while they typed.

So → Share sideways to peers who already use AI, never into a manager's monitoring view. Share the *method attached to a result* ("how the reconciliation took 20 min"), framed by the task, not "I used AI". Make sharing opt-in and credited, with prompt details shown only after the result. Never expose anyone's AI use without consent. This rules out silently scraping chat logs.

4 · The people with the best workflows have the strongest reasons to hoard them

32% of AI users keep their use secret from their employer. Their reasons: they want a "secret advantage" (36%), they fear job cuts (30%), or they feel like impostors (27%) (Ivanti, 6k workers). **Frequent users are more than 2× as likely as infrequent users to fear their job being eliminated**. That fear drops about 11 pts where workers feel the organization cares about them (Gallup, about 30k observations). A three-wave panel found that AI use raises *both* knowledge sharing and knowledge hiding, with hiding driven by job insecurity and amplified by a competitive climate.

So → Give authors something they value: named authorship, plus a record of "adopted by N colleagues, kept by M" that can be cited in performance reviews. Citi motivated 4,000 "AI Accelerators" with badges and no pay, and reached 70%+ adoption across 182k staff. Pair this with an explicit company policy that sharing a workflow does not trigger headcount cuts.

5 · Libraries don't spread practice. Only about 20% of shared assets get reused

Most assets go unused. BBVA had 3,000 GPTs built and 1,000 offered company-wide. That later grew to **20,000+ built, with about 4,000 used often**. Moderna had about 1,400–2,000 GPTs. Its most-reached GPT (Benefits) had 1,215 users, and its "GPT to find GPTs" had 84.

Assets without an owner duplicate. Moderna had **four travel-and-expense GPTs, and none was built by the T&E team**.

Public registries and older channels show the same pattern. On skills.sh, about half of 1M skills were installed once, and cross-industry skills get 3.6× more installs each. Enterprise social networks follow the same curve: 80% of Yammer users were active less than once every two weeks. A Booz Allen estimate put 84% of 1990s knowledge-management programs at no significant impact. OpenAI stops new custom-GPT creation on 26 Oct 2026.

What gets reused. Moderna's most-used GPTs were Self-Review (12,751 messages), Benefits and Feedback. All attach to *shared company moments*, not specialist work.

So → Don't build a library. Capture workflows passively from telemetry, as Gong does with sales calls, with the author's consent at publish. Assign an owner from the function the workflow serves. Push each workflow when its trigger arrives (review cycle, month end, claim intake). Retire anything without sustained reuse.

6 · A workflow people can run beats one they are taught

In a call center, a tool fine-tuned on top performers' chats lifted novices 30%. Agents with 2 months' experience matched agents with 6+ months, and the skill persisted during AI outages (Brynjolfsson et al., QJE 2025, 5,172 agents). Consultants below average gained 43% and those above average gained 17% (BCG/HBS). At P&G, people with AI matched two-person teams.

Telling workers about AI shifted what they believed but **not what they did** (Humlum & Vestergaard). Employer *encouragement* nearly doubled take-up, from 47% to 83%, and halved the gender gap. Zapier went from under 10% to over 50% daily use in **one week** of a hackathon on everyone's real work. Ramp's CPO: "training doesn't work." Half of AI performance gains come from users adapting their own prompts; auto-rewriting them made results 58% worse (MIT Sloan).

So → Ship each workflow as a runnable skill or agent, plus a short *adapt-to-my-context* step on the user's own files. Have the company visibly endorse AI use, which is a precondition for peer spread.

7 & 8 · Usage metrics get gamed; collecting only from the top 10% can dry up

Meta's "Claudeonomics" (ranking about 85k staff), Amazon's "Kirorank", Shopify's token leaderboard and Duolingo's AI review metric were all scrapped after "tokenmaxxing". Workslop has a cost too: 40% of desk workers received some in a month, and 42% then trusted the sender less. Brynjolfsson's top agents drifted toward copying the AI's suggestions.

So → Measure *adoption and 30-day retention by others*, plus outcome deltas, never volume. Give each shared workflow a built-in quality check, and show newcomers their first results privately. Reward new workflows in their own right.

What worked in real rollouts

COMPANY	MECHANISM	MEASURED RESULT
JPMorgan	Opt-in LLM Suite; AI Days; peer-visible usage by group; super-users trained the trainers	200k users; active share rose from 30% to 50% after super-user-led training
Zapier	Week-long, all-hands "code red" hackathon plus demo day; later a 4-level fluency rubric	Daily use <10% → >50% in a week; about 97% later †
Moderna	Prompt contest with winners chosen by peer reactions; CEO raised AI in every quarterly business review	About 75% active; most GPTs built outside the central AI team
BBVA	Found heavy users ("wizards") in analytics data and had them run peer workshops; 21-domain champion network	83% daily active; 2.8 h/week saved
Booking.com	Used telemetry to find teams of non-users, then ran targeted 3–5-day accelerators	Adoption +65%; daily users +16% throughput †
Intercom	IT pushes a skills repo to every laptop; per-skill telemetry; personal usage percentile	2× PRs per head in 9 months †
Microsoft	About 10k "Copilot Champs" on Viva Engage	*No effect size ever published*

Pattern: the measured gains come from champions **picked from usage data**, protected time on **real work**, and visible executive attention. Champion networks without data have no published effect.

Who is attacking Layer C, and what they miss

PLAYER	MECHANISM	WHAT'S MISSING VS. THE FULL LOOP
Section ProfAI coach (~$40M)	Recommends use cases by role; lets people share use cases company-wide	Use cases come from Section's catalog and self-reports, not observed top users. No uplift measurement
Microsoft Prompt Gallery, Viva Engage adoption community	Manual prompt sharing; one-click Copilot community; community agents due Sep 2026	Copilot only; relies on volunteers to share (the Yammer pattern)
Anthropic / OpenAI org skills, Skills	Publish to an org directory; admin provisioning; auto-updates	Packaging only. Single vendor. No peer targeting
Glean Agent Library	Build and share agents with groups; insights by creator	Glean-built agents only
Larridin, Worklytics	Spot power users and laggards from telemetry	Measurement only: they find power users but don't spread their workflows
June ($20M pre-seed)	Scans systems and builds agents top-down	Skips people entirely. Competes for the same "AI isn't landing" budget
Uplimit, Electives, Docebo	AI-run cohorts, workshops, LMS	Generic content; can't see actual AI use

What history teaches

Gong worked: top-performer diffusion as a product

Gong records calls passively, so no one has to volunteer. It libraries the "best of the best", ties behavior to win rate, and works through front-line managers. It reached a $500M ARR run rate, growing 55%+. The hard part to copy: AI work has no single outcome like a deal won.

Enterprise social networks failed: feeds produce lurkers

Microsoft bought Yammer for $1.2B, and it became a Viva feature. Jive sold for $462M, down from a ~$1.7B peak. Workplace from Meta shut down in Jun 2026. In one network, 97% of members lurked. "Champions posting tips in a community" is that same model.

Trailhead and Citi worked: status beats pay

Trailhead users earned 5M badges in about 3 years. Citi's badge-only accelerator network reached 70%+ adoption. Credentials and visibility motivate the top 10% to contribute.

Adoption tools get acquired at about $1B

WalkMe went to SAP ($1.5B) after 12% growth, and Sana to Workday (~$1.0B). Highspot and Seismic are merging. HR suites can't see AI behavior. Data on "workflow uplift by role" is the asset they would buy.

Proposed design: the Commons diffusion loop

1 · Detect
Telemetry finds repeated, high-value workflows by power users. Passive capture

2 · Package
Author consents. A runnable skill with a quality check and an owner from the function

3 · Target
Units at 10–25% adoption. Lookalike roles. Trigger on a recurring task

4 · Reinforce
About 3 signals from different contexts within 14 days. Peers, not managers

5 · Retain
Adapt to my context. Private first runs. Reinforce over about 11 weeks

6 · Credit & prove
Author's adoption record. Uplift by unit feeds the seat-renewal case

Steps 3–5 are what no one sells today. Analytics vendors stop at step 1, and platforms give away step 2. The metric to own is **diffusion velocity**: days for a workflow to reach 25% of its target unit, and the share still using it at day 30.

Buyer and budget

The buyer is the Head of AI or CAIO (61% control AI budget †) or the CIO at seat-renewal time. Only 5% of Copilot pilots were moving to scale (Gartner, 2025). M365 Copilot went from 15M to 30M+ seats in 2026 †, so renewal scrutiny is coming. Price against seat spend, not training spend: L&D is about $468 per learner at large companies, and training's share of AI budgets is shrinking †.

Risks and what to validate next

(1) The Microsoft peer effects are observational, and no RCT tests peer demos vs. training. **Run one with a design partner.** (2) Nobody publishes how concentrated authorship is or what share of usage runs through shared assets (OpenAI's aggregate is about 20%). **Commons could be first to publish this data.** (3) Privacy: any manager-facing view brings back the evaluator penalty. (4) Microsoft could bundle Viva, the Agent Store and Copilot Analytics, so stay multi-vendor.

Sources († = secondary or vendor-reported; all others read at the primary source or an official summary). Full links: *research/layer-c-sources.md*.

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Ivanti (May 2025); Gallup (2026); BetterUp/Stanford workslop (2025); MIT Sloan prompts study (2025)

HBS cases: Moderna 625-070, JPMorganChase 325-066; BBVA press (2025)† Dec figures

Zapier, Ramp, Intercom, Booking, Canva write-ups†; Fortune/HCAMag on leaderboards†

Vercel "State of agent skills" (Sep 2026); SWOOP ESN study; Gong via Calcalist (May 2026)

Microsoft WTI 2026; Section AI Proficiency (2026); Gartner via techpartner.news (2025)